

Mortar Beta — Plain-Language Guide for the Team

For: the Mortar program team (non-technical) **Companion to:** the full technical runbook (`BETA_TESTING_PLAN.md`) — you don't need to read that one. **Date:** 2026-06-17

Part 1 — The context (why we're doing this)

Mortar has two products that are supposed to work together like two halves of one experience:

- **The Digital Curriculum** — our online courses. People watch lessons, take quizzes, and earn certificates that teach them how to run a successful business.
- **The Expansion Network** — our alumni app. People connect with other alumni, message each other, join groups, post and find jobs/skills, attend events, and get matched with people who can help their business.

The big idea we're testing: someone learns business skills in the Curriculum → joins the Expansion Network as an alum → meets other alumni who help them (and whom they help back) → that activity keeps them coming back and spending money with Mortar → which keeps Mortar growing. It's a circle that should feed itself.

A "beta" is just a **supervised trial run** with a small group of real people **before** we open the doors to everyone. We do it to catch problems early and to find out whether the big idea actually works in real life — not just on paper.

The four things we most want to find out, in order of importance:

1. **Do alumni actually help each other?** (Our #1 question.) When we introduce two alumni, does anything real come of it — a job lead, a skill traded, an introduction, a partnership?
 2. **Do people use both apps, not just one?** Does learning in the Curriculum pull them into the Network, and vice versa?
 3. **Does the curriculum actually teach them something they use?** Do people know more — and *do* something differently in their business — after taking it?
 4. **Will people pay?** For a course, an event ticket, or merchandise.
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Part 2 — The instructions (what we do, week by week)

The whole beta runs **6 weeks**. Think of it in three stages.

Stage 1 — Weeks 1 & 2: "We test it ourselves"

Our own staff (about 5–8 of us) use both apps first and try to break things, so real users never hit an obvious problem.

What the team does:

1. Each staff member is assigned a "role" to play (a brand-new student, an alum, an admin) and one or both apps.
2. Go through everything a real user would: sign up, take a lesson, earn a certificate, send a message, post a job, register for an event, buy something.
3. Whenever something breaks, looks wrong, or is confusing — **write it down** (see "How to report a problem" below).

We don't move on until: nothing is seriously broken, and we've tried every major activity at least once.

Stage 2 — Week 3: "We fix what we found"

The tech team fixes the problems from Stage 1. The program team uses this week to **line up the outside testers** and write the invitation emails.

What the program team does this week:

1. Build the list of outside testers (details in the next section).
2. Draft the welcome/invite email and have it ready to send.
3. Get the sign-off that everything's fixed and we're "ready for real people."

We don't move on until: the serious problems are fixed and the invitation has been tested on one practice account from start to finish.

Stage 3 — Weeks 4, 5 & 6: "Real people try it"

Now we invite our outside testers (about 30 people — see below) and watch how it goes.

- **Week 4 — Get them in and learning.** Send invitations. Make sure everyone successfully signs up in both apps. Have them start a course. **Ask them a few quick questions up front** about their business knowledge (this is our "before" snapshot — we can't get it later, so don't skip it).
- **Week 5 — Connecting and buying.** Encourage alumni to look at their suggested matches, message each other, set up a call, and post/browse jobs and skills. Open up the things people can pay for (a course, an event ticket, merch) and see if anyone buys. Run at least one real event.
- **Week 6 — Wrap up and decide.** Ask the same business-knowledge questions again (the "after" snapshot). Interview a handful of alumni about whether any connection actually helped them. Look at all the numbers and stories together and decide: **are we ready to launch?**

Throughout Weeks 4–6 (the rhythm):

- Every day: someone checks for any serious problem reports.

- Twice a week: a short 30-minute check-in call with testers to hear how it's going and nudge anyone who's gone quiet.
- Once a week: pull the numbers so we're not scrambling at the end.

Who the outside testers are (about 30 people)

Group	How many	Why
Alumni	About 20 (at least 12)	They're the heart of the test — they're the ones who connect, message, and help each other. If we can't get at least 12, we should wait , because the network needs enough people to be useful.
Students	About 10	They test the learning, certificates, and buying experience. (Students don't get the alumni app — that's by design.)

The most important recruiting tip: hand-pick alumni who **already run a business** and who **need different things from each other** — for example, someone who needs a graphic designer *and* someone who offers design. The whole point is for them to help each other, so we need real "I can help you / you can help me" pairs in the group. This one choice matters more than almost anything else.

How to report a problem (everyone uses the same method)

When something goes wrong or feels off, write it down with:

- **What you were doing** (e.g., "trying to buy the course"),
- **What happened** vs. what you expected,
- **How bad it is**, using these labels:

Label	Means	Example
Blocker	Can't continue / lost money / a real problem	App crashes; payment fails; can't sign up
Major	Important thing is broken	Messaging doesn't send
Minor	Annoying but you can work around it	A button is in the wrong place
Polish	Cosmetic	A typo, odd spacing

Send it to the beta Slack channel or the feedback form. The tech team handles fixes; "Blocker" and "Major" issues get looked at the same day.

Part 3 — Reading the results (how we'll know it worked)

At the end we look at **two scorecards**. We launch only if **both** look good.

Scorecard A — "Does it work?" (the basics)

- The apps don't crash for people.
- Nobody is stuck on a "Blocker" problem.
- The key things work for real: signing up, learning, getting reminders, paying, and emails arriving.

If this scorecard fails, we're not ready — full stop.

Scorecard B — "Does the big idea work?" (our four questions)

Because this is a small group, we pair every **number** with **real stories** from people. A number alone doesn't count — we want to hear *why*.

Our question	What "good" looks like	The story we need
1. Do alumni help each other?	At least 5 real cases where a connection led to something concrete (a lead, a skill traded, an intro, a partnership)	5 alumni telling us, in their words, how a connection helped their business
2. Do people use both apps?	At least half the alumni active in both the Curriculum and the Network	Testers describing the two as one connected experience, not two separate things
3. Does the curriculum teach?	A clear "before vs. after" improvement for most people who finish a module, plus 5 people who <i>did something</i> in their business because of it	5 "I changed X in my business because of a lesson" stories
4. Will people pay?	At least 5 real purchases, across at least 2 of: courses, event tickets, merch	Buyers explaining why it was worth it; non-buyers explaining what stopped them

(These targets are starting points for a ~30-person group — we can adjust them with the tech lead once we see the real cohort.)

Making the call

- **Both scorecards good** → launch, and keep improving.
- **Scorecard A fails** → not ready; fix and re-test.
- **Scorecard A good but Scorecard B is weak** → the apps work, but the *idea* needs more proof. We decide together: launch and keep refining, or extend the trial to strengthen the weak spot. Either way, we write down the decision and why.

One thing to plan around

A few behind-the-scenes pieces must be finished **before** we invite outside testers in Week 4 — especially the real app links in the invitation email and the live payment setup. The tech team owns these; the

program team just needs to know that **Week 4 can't start until they confirm those are done.**